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A different homecoming



The 15th edition of the ASEAN Championship has been a **potpourri** of upsets, emerging stars, and foreign players, with or without Asian heritage, shining for their respective national teams.

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Indonesia, the runner-up at the AFF U-23 Championship and a semifinalist at the previous edition of the ASEAN Championship, was stunned by the Philippines, which secured a final-four spot after six years.

The winning goal in that match came from Bjorn Kristensen, a Norway-born forward who chose to play for the Philippines as his mother is from the country.

Meanwhile, defending champion Thailand saw the emergence of new youngsters in forward Patrik Gustavsson (**above, in blue**) and Nicholas Mickelson (defender), both of whom have a Thai mother but were born in Europe.

Gustavsson and Kristensen were crucial in the semifinal, with Thailand finally securing a late winner — courtesy of Suphanat Mueanta — to



set up a repeat of the last edition's final against Vietnam.

However, the biggest surprise import was Vietnam's Brazil-born forward Rafaelson, who, after naturalisation, changed his name to Nguyen Xuan Son.

The 27-year-old scored three of Vietnam's five goals across two legs of the semifinal against Singapore and is the highest scorer in the tournament with five goals.

Renard to the fore, again

Saudi Arabia found itself in choppy waters under Euro 2020-winning coach Roberto Mancini.

The team won only seven of 18 games and finished outside the automatic qualification spots for the 2026 FIFA World Cup in the third

round.

Enter Frenchman Herve Renard (**above, in white**), the head coach whose fiery speech inspired a shock victory for the Saudis against eventual world champion Argentina in Qatar two years ago.

Renard had moved to the French women's national team after his stint with Saudi Arabia but returned to coach the side in October.

Within two months, the team appears to be firing on all cylinders, having knocked out defending Arabian Gulf Cup champion Iraq from the 2024 edition.

In the semifinals, the Saudis will play Oman, while Bahrain will face Kuwait, with the final scheduled for January 4.